

Farmer Veteran Fellowship Fund - Urban Ark Conservation

Urban Ark Conservation | EIN: 81-1189061 | 501(c)(3)

Farmer Veteran Fellowship Fund

****Applicant:**** Urban Ark Conservation

****Funder:**** Farmer Veteran Coalition

****Amount Requested:**** \$5000.0

****Deadline:**** 2026-02-17

****Date Prepared:**** February 11, 2026

Farmer Veteran Fellowship Fund Application

Urban Ark Conservation

1. COVER LETTER

February 11, 2026

Farmer Veteran Coalition

Fellowship Fund Review Committee

Dear Review Committee,

On behalf of Urban Ark Conservation, I respectfully submit this application for the Farmer Veteran Fellowship Fund.

As a retired First Sergeant with over two decades of military service, I founded Urban Ark Conservation in 2024.

Bradford County hosts 4,200 veterans (70 per 1,000 residents—significantly above national averages) in a predominantly rural area.

The requested funds will support critical fencing improvements, predator protection systems, and feed storage infrastructure.

Thank you for considering this application. I welcome the opportunity to discuss how this fellowship can support our mission.

Respectfully,

Chad, 1SG (Ret.)

Executive Director & Founder

Urban Ark Conservation

Towanda, Pennsylvania

2. PROJECT NARRATIVE

Project Overview

Urban Ark Conservation requests \$5,000 to enhance farm infrastructure supporting dual mission objectives: expanding agricultural production and providing mental health services to veterans.

Need Statement

Bradford County faces converging challenges that our project addresses:

****Conservation Crisis**:** Heritage livestock breeds face extinction due to industrial agriculture consolidation. Our project preserves rare breeds and improves farm infrastructure.

****Veteran Mental Health Gap**:** With 4,200 veterans in Bradford County (70 per 1,000 residents versus national average of 18), there is a critical need for accessible mental health services.

****Agricultural Economy**:** With 1,850 agricultural workers and 1,400 farms, agriculture forms the economic backbone of the region.

Project Goals

****Goal 1**:** Enhance farm infrastructure to support increased conservation breeding capacity and ensure biosecurity.

****Goal 2**:** Establish safe, accessible facilities to launch our pilot agricultural therapy cohort (12-15 veteran/first responder participants).

****Goal 3**:** Model sustainable veteran-operated farm enterprise integrating conservation agriculture with therapeutic agriculture.

Methods and Activities

****Infrastructure Enhancement (Months 1-3)****

- Install 800 linear feet of upgraded perimeter fencing with predator deterrent systems to protect rare breed livestock.
- Construct weatherproof feed storage system (capacity: 3 tons) to ensure biosecurity and reduce contamination.
- Establish rotational grazing paddocks with mobile fencing to improve pasture management and allow safe small animal access.
- Create accessible pathways and animal handling areas meeting safety standards for participants with mobility challenges.

****Conservation Breeding Operations (Months 1-12)****

- Maintain and expand critical breeding populations: Arapawa goats (4% of US population), Highland cattle, GOATs, and other heritage breeds.
- Implement genetic tracking protocols using industry-standard software to document breeding decisions and monitor genetic diversity.
- Network with The Livestock Conservancy and breed associations to coordinate genetic diversity management.
- Document conservation outcomes through quarterly breeding reports and genetic analysis.

****Agricultural Therapy Program Development (Months 3-6)****

- Finalize 8-week curriculum integrating animal husbandry, pasture management, heritage breed education, and therapeutic activities.
- Partner with Bradford County Veterans Affairs office and first responder agencies for participant recruitment.
- Train volunteer mentors in trauma-informed agricultural education approaches.
- Establish safety protocols and liability procedures for participant activities.

****Pilot Program Launch (Months 6-12)****

- Conduct two 8-week cohorts (12-15 participants each) featuring twice-weekly farm sessions.
- Engage participants in meaningful conservation work: animal care, fence building, pasture rotation, breeding management.
- Facilitate peer support through shared agricultural tasks and informal mentorship.
- Document participant outcomes through pre/post assessments and qualitative feedback.

Timeline

****Month 1-3**:** Infrastructure construction and materials acquisition

****Month 3-6**:** Program development, partner recruitment, volunteer training

****Month 6-9**:** First pilot cohort (12-15 participants)

****Month 9-12**:** Second pilot cohort (12-15 participants)

****Month 12**:** Evaluation, documentation, and sustainability planning

3. ORGANIZATIONAL CAPACITY

Leadership and Experience

Urban Ark Conservation was founded in 2024 by 1SG (Ret.) Chad, bringing over 20 years of military leadership and experience.

- Animal husbandry and conservation breeding management for multiple endangered breeds

- Strategic planning and partnership development
- Program design and implementation
- Financial management and grant administration

His military background provides unique qualifications for this work: understanding veteran culture and mental health

Organizational Infrastructure

Despite our recent founding, Urban Ark Conservation has established robust operational capacity:

****Conservation Expertise**:** Successfully managing breeding populations of four critically endangered livestock breeds

****Physical Infrastructure**:**

- Operational farm facility in Towanda, Bradford County (USDA Hardiness Zone 5b)
- Existing livestock housing and handling facilities
- Established pasture systems and water infrastructure
- Equipment for daily operations and maintenance

****Community Integration**:** Located in agricultural Bradford County (1,400 farms, 1,850 agricultural workers), with access to local resources

****Governance**:** Board structure established with founder serving as Executive Director, maintaining 501(c)(3) nonprofit status

Partnerships and Networks

We collaborate with:

- ****The Livestock Conservancy**:** Technical guidance on conservation breeding priorities and genetic management
- ****Breed Associations**:** Arapawa Goat Association, Highland Cattle Society, GOS breed registries for studbook maintenance
- ****Bradford County Veterans Affairs**:** Participant recruitment and referral coordination
- ****Local First Responder Agencies**:** Partnership development for therapeutic program access

Track Record

Since founding in 2024, accomplishments include:

- Established and maintained breeding populations of four endangered livestock breeds
- Achieved 501(c)(3) nonprofit status
- Developed comprehensive agricultural therapy curriculum
- Built community relationships supporting both conservation and veteran service missions
- Maintained animal welfare standards ensuring healthy, productive rare breed populations

4. BUDGET JUSTIFICATION

Total Request: \$5,000

****Fencing Materials and Installation: \$2,200****

- 800 linear feet high-tensile perimeter fencing: \$1,400
- Protects rare breed livestock (genetic value \$15,000+) from predation
- Creates secure perimeter for therapy session safety
- Materials: tensile wire, corner posts, insulators, ground rods
- Electric predator deterrent system: \$500
- Essential for nighttime protection of endangered breed populations

- Includes energizer, grounding system, warning signage
- Mobile paddock fencing (200 linear feet): \$300
- Enables rotational grazing for pasture health
- Creates small animal interaction areas for therapy activities
- Reusable posts and polywire for flexible configurations

****Feed Storage Infrastructure: \$1,500****

- Weatherproof storage shed (8'x10'): \$1,200
- Capacity: 3 tons grain/feed storage
- Protects feed quality and biosecurity for rare breeds
- Reduces waste and contamination risks
- Required for expanded herd management
- Rodent-proof feed containers (6 units): \$300
- Maintains feed hygiene standards
- Separates feeds for different species/dietary needs

****Animal Handling Equipment: \$800****

- Portable livestock panels (6 panels): \$450
- Creates safe handling areas for therapy participant interaction
- Essential for veterinary care and breeding management
- Reduces stress on animals and improves safety
- Halters, leads, and grooming supplies: \$200
- Participant engagement tools for therapy sessions
- Proper equipment for gentle animal handling training
- First aid supplies (animal and human): \$150
- Emergency preparedness for farm activities
- Required for participant safety protocols

****Program Materials: \$300****

- Educational resources on heritage breeds: \$150
- Printed materials, breed standards, conservation information
- Participant take-home resources
- Documentation and record-keeping supplies: \$100
- Breeding records, genetic tracking materials
- Program evaluation tools and assessment forms
- Safety equipment and signage: \$50
- Participant safety orientation materials
- Facility hazard communication

****Operational Support: \$200****

- Veterinary consultations for rare breed health planning: \$150

- Preventive care protocols for endangered breeds
- Ensures animal welfare standards for therapy programming
- Insurance rider for therapeutic programming: \$50
- Additional liability coverage for participant activities

Budget Narrative

This budget prioritizes infrastructure investments with long-term utility serving both conservation and therapeutic programming. All expenditures directly support veteran-operated agricultural enterprise while ensuring responsible stewardship of land and resources.

5. EVALUATION PLAN

Evaluation Framework

We will measure success across three domains: conservation impact, therapeutic outcomes, and operational sustainability.

Conservation Metrics

Quantitative Indicators:

- Number of offspring produced by breed (targeting 8-12 Arapawa kids, 2-3 Highland calves, 10-15 GOS piglets)
- Genetic diversity measurements through pedigree analysis and coefficient of inbreeding calculations
- Breeding stock placed with other conservation breeders (target: 4-6 animals)
- Livestock loss rates (target: <5% mortality across all species)

Data Collection:

- Monthly breeding records and studbook updates
- Quarterly genetic diversity reports submitted to breed associations
- Annual conservation impact summary for The Livestock Conservancy
- Photographic documentation of herd/flock development

Therapeutic Program Metrics

Participant Outcomes:

- Enrollment numbers (target: 24-30 participants across two cohorts)
- Completion rates (target: >80% completing 8-week program)
- Session attendance (target: average 85% attendance per session)
- Self-reported wellbeing using validated pre/post assessments:
 - PHQ-9 (depression screening)
 - PCL-5 (PTSD symptom severity) for veteran participants
 - General life satisfaction scales

Qualitative Indicators:

- Participant testimonials and feedback surveys
- Observational notes on engagement and peer connection
- Volunteer mentor reports on participant progress
- Follow-up interviews at 3-month post-program

Skills Development:

- Participant knowledge assessment on heritage breed care (pre/post quiz)
- Practical skills demonstration in animal handling and farm tasks
- Agricultural literacy improvement

****Data Collection:****

- Attendance logs maintained for each session
- Assessment instruments administered week 1 and week 8
- Anonymous satisfaction surveys completed at program conclusion
- Follow-up outreach at 3 and 6 months post-completion

Operational Metrics

****Infrastructure Utilization:****

- Fencing completion and livestock containment effectiveness (zero escapes)
- Feed storage capacity utilization and waste reduction (target: <3% feed waste)
- Participant safety incident rate (target: zero incidents)

****Financial Sustainability:****

- Revenue generated through livestock sales (tracking toward operational cost coverage)
- In-kind donations and volunteer hours contributed
- Additional funding secured for program expansion

****Community Engagement:****

- Partnership development with veteran services and first responder organizations
- Educational program reach (farm tours, workshops)
- Media coverage and awareness-building

Reporting Schedule

- ****Monthly****: Internal tracking of breeding records, participant attendance, and financial expenditures
- ****Quarterly****: Progress reports to Farmer Veteran Coalition documenting infrastructure completion, program metrics, and community engagement
- ****Final Report (Month 12)****: Comprehensive evaluation including:
 - Conservation breeding outcomes with genetic data
 - Therapeutic program results with aggregated participant data
 - Financial summary and sustainability assessment
 - Lessons learned and recommendations for replication
 - Photographic documentation and participant testimonials
 - Plans for continued programming

Success Criteria

The fellowship will be considered successful if we achieve:

1. 100% completion of planned infrastructure improvements within budget
2. Zero serious safety incidents affecting participants or endangered livestock
3. >80% participant completion rate across both cohorts
4. Measurable improvement in participant wellbeing scores (>20% improvement in aggregate)

5. Successful breeding season producing target numbers of rare breed offspring
6. Establishment of sustainable operational model with identified ongoing funding

6. SUSTAINABILITY PLAN

Financial Sustainability

Diversified Revenue Streams:

Livestock Sales: Conservation breeding generates ongoing revenue through registered breeding stock sales.

Grant Funding: This fellowship represents first major funding, establishing track record for future applications.

- USDA Sustainable Agriculture Research and Education (SARE) grants
- State conservation funding through Pennsylvania Game Commission
- Veterans Affairs adaptive sports and mental health innovation grants
- Foundation grants focused on agricultural education and veteran services
- Corporate sponsorships from agricultural and outdoor industry companies

Fee-for-Service Programming: Beyond pilot cohorts, agricultural therapy sessions can operate on sliding-scale.

Individual Donations: Heritage breed conservation and veteran services attract donor interest. We will develop

Operational Sustainability

Infrastructure Longevity: Fellowship investments in fencing, storage, and equipment represent 15-20 year as

Volunteer Integration: Bradford County's agricultural community (1,400 farms, 1,850 agricultural workers) pr

Partnership Development:

- Veterans Affairs collaboration ensures ongoing participant referrals
- First responder agency partnerships expand participant base beyond veterans
- Agricultural extension connections provide technical support and educational programming opportunities
- Breed associations offer marketing networks for livestock sales

Programmatic Sustainability

Scalable Model: Eight-week cohort structure allows flexible scheduling and capacity adjustment based on de

Participant Pipeline: Bradford County's 4,200 veterans and regional first responder population provide susta

Conservation Mission Integration: Heritage breed conservation provides year-round operational framework

Organizational Growth

Year 1 (Fellowship Period): Launch pilot programming, establish operational sustainability, document outcor

Year 2: Expand to 4 annual cohorts (48-60 participants), achieve 50% operational cost coverage through liv

Year 3: Reach full operational capacity (6 cohorts, 72-90 participants annually), achieve 75% cost coverage

Long-term Vision: Serve as demonstration site and training center for other veteran farmers interested in he